
UNIT 1 UNIVERSAL HUMAN VALUES*

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1.0 OBJECTIVES

After going through this unit, you will be able to:

- explain the meaning of human values and how they have been universally conceived;
- discuss the notions of human values from individual and universal perspectives;
- highlight the importance of various pillars of human values;
- identify the role of human values in dictating day-to-day decision-making choices; and
- recognise the potential and relevance of human values for general well-being.

1.2 INTRODUCTION

Human values can be understood as the values that have been conceived and preferred by the people in a society that has inspired their actual conduct and behaviour and prepared them to attain the best in their lives. Human values involve the process of selection, preference and acceptance of certain values for life.

For instance, humans are considered as social animals who have evolved a very complex social system with the enhanced capacity to retain, transmit and improve upon the knowledge they possess. Throughout the evolution of humankind, understanding of people according to their environment has changed drastically. The process of change that humans have experienced

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in different stages of their lives is to a greater extent influenced by human values within a society.

The nucleus of society's advancement has been the ever progressing and evolving thoughts and ideals of people. Human values, in this regard too have evolved through time and remains to do so as per the changing social and cultural environment of a society. The complication emerges when people of a society are subjected to different types of social environments and hence, their values tend to shape differently. Individually, values can be different but on a collective level, the common qualities can be seen as the social glue, which binds them together in a society. These values that people hold to be significant and desirable are referred to as human values. These human values are embedded deeply and influence attitudes, conclusions, and actions of people. They represent the things that are valued, significant, and worthwhile in life, including truthfulness, integrity, respect, compassion, freedom and justice. They serve as a basis for moral decision-making and help people decide what they believe to be right or bad in light of their own personal or cultural convictions.

Human values, as discussed by Nicolai Hartmann (1967), can be understood as the conditions which determine and shape human culture and also is conditioned by it in order to gain universal acceptance.



1.2 UNDERSTANDING HUMAN VALUES

Tracing the origin of human values can be a complex process, as these values have multiple sources of origin. Human values have always aimed to be constructive in nature, which in turn could provide a sense of balance and collective engagement within a society.

It is important to state that human values have evolved over a very long period. Humans have created and recreated them based on their social and cultural surroundings such as:

- **Influences from Culture and Society:** Culture has a big impact on how people value things. The socialization processes that take place in families, communities, educational institutions, and larger cultural contexts frequently result in the transmission of values. Specific values within a culture can arise and are reinforced through cultural norms, traditions, and practices.
- **Family and Upbringing:** The formation of human values is significantly influenced by family dynamics and upbringing. An individual's value system is greatly influenced by the values they are taught by their parents or other key caregivers, as well as by the family's cultural, religious, or ideological backgrounds.

- **Formal Institutions and Education:** Education, both formal and informal, is a key factor in determining values. Values can be taught at educational institutions through their curricula, instructional strategies, and extracurricular activities. The development of people's value systems can be influenced by the values that are promoted in educational systems and institutions.
- **Personal Experiences and Interactions:** Human values can be shaped and altered through personal experiences, such as social interactions and exposure to various viewpoints. Events can have a positive or negative impact on a person's values by causing them to reflect and reevaluate their views and priorities. Examples of such events include personal successes, hardships, or experiencing injustice.
- **Media and Popular Culture:** By promoting popular ideas, customs, and lifestyles, media, including television, films, books, and social media, can shape values. A person's exposure to new ideas, challenges to their held beliefs, or reinforcement of society values can all be influenced by the media.
- **Religion and Spirituality:** For many people, religion and spiritual beliefs play a crucial role in forming the core of their human values. A framework for moral principles, ethical precepts and value systems that affect believers' behaviours and decision-making is frequently provided by religious teachings and scriptures.
- **Evolutionary and Biological Factors:** According to some academics, some values may have evolved because they promote social cohesiveness and cooperation. A person's propensity for specific values or moral judgments may also be influenced to some extent by biological variables like genetics and brain shape.

1.3 HUMAN VALUES FROM INDIVIDUAL TO UNIVERSAL PERSPECTIVES

Human values as a concept can be interpreted from different individual perspectives as it has multiple nodes of origin. For instance, in the case of India, the very notion of human values can be understood from four "purusartha" which identify 'Artha', 'Kama', 'Dharma' and 'Moksha' as fundamental human values. These values have been defined among others by Kautilya and Vatsayana. According to these scholars, 'Artha' has been interpreted as the value of existence and maintenance of human life. It emphasizes on material gain and physical well-being. 'Kama' has been defined as the pleasure resulting from satisfaction of desires. The sensuous desires have been interpreted in the form of gratification which is necessary for human well-being. 'Dharma' has been interpreted as the law or principles of integration and maintenance of things. Lastly, 'Moksha' reflects the supreme goal of human life which is liberation or salvation from the effects of 'Karma'.

Similarly, from Buddhist perspectives human values have been defined based on four eternal truths. These truths have been identified as 'Shashwat Satya'. The truths are as under:

- a) Life is not devoid of sorrows, suffering and anguish, etc.
- b) The anguish and suffering have a cause.
- c) The suffering that an individual faces can be put to an end.
- d) There are many ways and means through which pain and suffering can be overcome in life.

Buddhism in this regard has also elaborated that if a person is unable to define the real vs unreal due to ignorance, then that person is bound to suffer. As a result, the ultimate goal of the individual is to make himself or herself self-aware about his or her surroundings that can help him or her to achieve true knowledge for liberation. Buddhism has recommended the eight-fold path that can help an individual to lead a balanced life and well-being. These are as under:

- a) Right Perception (Samyak Drishti).
- b) Right Determination (Samyak Samkalpa).
- c) Right Speech (Samyak Vaka).
- d) Right Conduct (Samyak Karma).
- e) Right Vocation (Samyak Ajivika).
- f) Right Exercise (Samyak Vijayama).
- g) Right Memory (Samyak Smriti).
- h) Right Meditation (Samyak Samadhi).

Human values ultimately take a universal shape if they are similar in practice among different cultures throughout the world. The meaning behind each value is uniform and universally accepted across different social and cultural spaces. Some of the human values which have gained a universal acceptance are:

1. Un-Biasness
2. Loyalty
3. Cooperation
4. Transparency
5. Objectivity
6. Discipline
7. Inspiration
8. Social Responsibility
9. Managing Conflict

The presence of universal human values in any organization or a society can help in enhancing the credibility among the stakeholders, facilitating decision-making choices in a rational way, promoting self-discipline, encouraging objectivity in life and most importantly ensuring trust and balance among the individuals in a larger setup.

One of the stark differences that can be seen between individual and universal human values can be that individual human values are directly concerned with the development of human personality. It focuses on reshaping the individual's norms and outlook towards honesty, loyalty and honour. On the other hand, universal human values are those which have a greater social and cultural acceptance, and these values are oriented towards human growth and development. Despite the difference between the two, universal human values take shape only when individual human values gradually take shape into a collective and gain a mass acceptance from different socio-cultural spaces of society.

1.4 HUMAN VALUES DICTATING DAY-TO-DAY LIFE DECISIONS

It is important to point out that our daily decision-making processes are greatly influenced by human values. They have an impact on the decisions we take, the steps we take, and the behaviour we display in different spheres of life. Human values have the following effects on our decision-making process:

1. **Prioritization:** By identifying which possibilities are consistent with our values, human values enable us to prioritize what is important in our lives and directs our decision-making accordingly. For instance, if we value honesty, we are more likely to incorporate it in our lives when interacting with others and making decisions, even if it is more challenging or uncomfortable for us.
2. **Ethics:** Human values act as a moral compass for us, helping us to discriminate between right and wrong. They aid in our analysis of the ethical consequences of our choices and deeds. Fairness, integrity, and compassion are examples of values that can help us make morally right judgments by motivating us to think about how our actions will affect other people.
3. **Setting Objectives:** Our personal goals are influenced by our values. They influence our desires and define what we regard as important and satisfying. The course we take in life and the goals we choose for ourselves are determined by our values. For instance, if we place a high value on personal development, we might make seeking educational or professional development opportunities our top priority.
4. **Relationships and Interactions:** Our relationships and social interactions are influenced by our values. They help us make decisions about our friendships, partnerships, and team projects. Trust, respect, and empathy are values that affect how we treat people and the kinds of interactions we strive to build.
5. **Personal Well-Being:** Our general happiness and well-being are influenced by human values. We feel genuine, content, and peaceful when we make choices that are consistent with our core beliefs. Internal turmoil, remorse, and discontent can result from disregarding or acting contrary to our ideals.
6. **Long-Term Effects:** Values encourage us to think about the long-term effects of our choices. They encourage us to contemplate the bigger picture of how our decisions affect us, those around us, and the planet beyond the immediate gains or short-term benefits. For instance, if we prioritize conservation and lessen our ecological footprint, we may make decisions that reflect this goal.
7. **Self-Reflection and Self-Awareness:** Reflecting on oneself and being aware of oneself are encouraged by values. We can better understand our motives, beliefs, and desires by looking at our values. Because of our increased self-awareness, we can make choices that are in line with who we truly are and advance our personal development.

It is, therefore, important to remember that people may prioritize and interpret values in different ways, resulting in a range of viewpoints and approaches to decision-making. Furthermore, social and cultural factors may have an impact on the values that are stressed and reinforced in a specific setting. Human values nevertheless play a significant role in our daily decision-making, guiding us through the challenges of life and ensuring that our deeds are consistent with our fundamental beliefs.

Check Your Progress 1

1. Discuss the key points which determine how human values are formed.

2. Briefly explain how human values dictate the choices one makes in the one's day-to-day lives.

1.5 PILLARS OF HUMAN VALUES

It is important to note that human values have certain fundamentals which are necessary for any society to exist in a state of balance. These fundamentals are as under:

- a) Truth
- b) Love
- c) Peace
- d) Non-Violence
- e) Righteous Conduct

These fundamentals are not only interrelated but also inherent in human beings which define their human-like qualities. These fundamentals can be seen important for human values because they are in line with the human beings and give rise to many other related values in different social and cultural spaces. As a result, understanding human values without these fundamentals may provide a distorted or a narrow outlook to how human values help in promoting a state of balance within a society.

In the case of 'Truth', it is an important fundamental which dictates our conscience. It is relative and keeps changing according value, to circumstances. It provides a sense of integrity in life and therefore is a very important human value.

'Love' can be understood as a spontaneous feeling which is affected by the sub-conscious mind. It is different from emotion. It helps in ensuring that one person is sensitive to the sense of happiness and well-being of the other. It is a value which binds people and allows them to exist as a collective unit.

'Peace', on the other hand, projects a state of mind which is indifferent towards the superfluous desires and needs or the urge to acquire resources

in vast proportions. Peace denotes the willpower of the individual in disconnecting himself from the superficial elements of society and lead a life of freedom and balance.

‘Non-violence’ reflects the tendency of an individual in acquiring something without the need for conflict or violating anything. It can be considered as one of the highest achievements of humans living in a state of harmony. Non-violence, however, also requires love in order to ensure that the actions of an individual do not violate anything and there is a state of balance.

‘Righteous conduct’, on the other hand, focuses on the actions of the individual and to what degree it is not biased, based on conscious decision-making that is rational and fair. This is another important fundamental of human values that encourages collective engagement of people in a society.

Thus, what can be seen in regard to human values is that these fundamentals are the core which shape human values and also redefine to be universally accepted across the globe. Since these fundamentals are interlinked, the existence of one also influences the existence of other, which in turn defines the human values in absolute.

1.6 RELEVANCE OF HUMAN VALUES

The ability of humans to comprehend the environment and adapt to the changes, whether it be physical or mental is astonishing. Humans have been undergoing different degrees of difficulties and have also overcome them with great efficiency. It has also become a part of people’s consciousness that their challenges cannot be addressed while ignoring human values. These values have become the guiding force which encourage people to consider each other’s values and treat each other with equal respect and dignity.

Human identity is fundamentally defined and shaped by human ideals. They affect people’s thoughts, beliefs, behaviours, and relations, adding to our understanding of what it is to be human. Here is how having human values makes one more human:

- **Reflection on Past Experience:** Our feeling of purpose, meaning, and what we regard as significant in life are all closely related to human values. They are a reflection of our ideas of what is just, moral, and true. Values compel people to consider their motives, behaviour, and effects on both themselves and other people. One thing that sets humans apart from other creatures is the capacity for reflection.
- **Making Moral Decisions:** Human values serve as a moral compass that directs people in coming to ethical conclusions. Our perceptions of right and wrong are influenced by values like honesty, compassion, justice, and integrity, which also shape our behaviours and actions. One of the most important aspects of being human is having the ability to make moral decisions.
- **Shaping Interactions:** Human values shape our interactions with others and how we traverse our social environment, which in turn shapes our behaviour and relationships. Harmonious relationships, empathy, and a sense of community are fostered through values like respect, empathy, and cooperation. Our behaviour and how we treat

others is governed by our values, which nurture traits that are crucial for human social relationships.

- **Personal Growth:** Personal growth is hugely influenced by human values. Individuals are motivated to learn new things, acquire new talents, and improve themselves by values like learning, curiosity, and self-improvement. Values give inspiration and guidance for self-reflection, experience-based learning, and the pursuit of personal excellence.
- **Identity:** Human values are intricately entwined with our sense of identity, which is expressed as individual identity. They showcase our distinctive viewpoints, convictions, and goals. Values enable people to express their uniqueness and make decisions that are consistent with who they truly are. The richness and complexity of the human identity are enriched by the diversity of values among individuals.
- **Well-being:** Human values are frequently linked to happiness and the desire for a happy life. Compassion, kindness, and altruism are virtues that benefit both the self and others. People can foster happy feelings, create lasting relationships, and improve their communities by upholding these ideals.

Thus, human values are relevant for human life, as they help in shaping an understanding about how people can identify what basic human values mean and how can they be incorporated in their day-to-day practices for positive well-being.

Check Your Progress 2

1. What are the fundamental pillars of human values?

2. How are human values translated into universal values?

1.7 LET US SUM UP

This unit provided an understanding of what human values mean and how they have different sources of origin. They ultimately focus on positive well-being and a state of balance in society. We learnt that human values do not emerge as universal values. They undergo different stages of transformation where individual values ultimately gain a collective recognition, which defines these values as universal in nature. Further, the role of human values in the day-to-day activities of individuals and how it promotes a rational engagement in society was discussed. This unit enabled the learner to gain clarity in terms of how one can conduct himself in a manner that encourages unity, peace and a state of balance in society. Lastly, the unit highlighted the fundamental pillars like 'Truth', 'Love', 'Peace', 'Non-Violence' and 'Righteous Conduct' which are crucial to understand human values.

1.8 KEY WORDS

- **Truth:** It is an important fundamental value which dictates our conscience. It is not relative and changing according to circumstances.
- **Love:** It can be understood as a spontaneous feeling which is affected by the sub-conscious mind. It is different from every-day emotion.
- **Peace:** It projects a state of mind which is indifferent towards the superfluous desires and needs or the urge to acquire resources in vast proportions.
- **Non-Violence:** It reflects the tendency of an individual in acquiring something without the need for conflict or violating anything. It can be considered as one of the highest achievements of human living in a state of harmony.
- **Samyak Drishti:** Right Perception.
- **Samyak Samkalpa:** Right Determination.
- **Samyak Karma:** Right Conduct.

1.9 SOME USEFUL BOOKS/ARTICLES/LINKS

Dagar, B.S and Dhull, I. (1994). *Perspectives in Moral Education*. Uppal Publishing House, New Delhi.

Gogate, S.B. (2011). *Human Values and Professional Ethics*. Vikas Publishing House, New Delhi.

Sinha, K. (2021). *Human Values and Virtues in Indian Perspectives*. B.R. Publishing Corporation.

1.10 ANSWERS TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS EXERCISES

Check your Progress 1

1. See Section 1.2
2. See Section 1.3

Check your Progress 2

1. See Section 1.4
2. See Section 1.5